

CORN SNAKE · *PANTHEROPHIS GUTTATUS*

Keep your corn snake the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: the enclosure size a preference test actually supports, the one piece of equipment with no exceptions, feeding by weight, health triage, and the routines that carry a snake past 20 years.

22 pages

Beginner friendly

Print or tablet

Version 1.0 · Sep 2026



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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 4 through 9 in order before buying anything. Corn snakes are a genuinely forgiving species to set up correctly, with one non-negotiable exception on page 5. The other decision worth getting right the first time is enclosure size, because for this species it is also the enrichment, and page 9 has the preference test behind that. Then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 16.

If your snake is already set up

Jump to the Setup Checklist and Climate Targets on page 14 to audit what you have, and page 10 if anything seems off. If your snake won't eat, start on page 13 instead: refusal in this species has seven common explanations and only one of them is illness. And if you have a heat source without a thermostat, fix that today.

Print these first

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Page 14: Setup Checklist & Climate Targets | ☐ Page 19: Daily & Weekly Routine |
| ☐ Page 15: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 20: Owner Log |
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WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Corn snakes are the best-studied snake in the hobby, and the research contradicts one of the most repeated lines in snake keeping. Page 9 gives you that in full. Where sources genuinely disagree, on humidity and on hatchling feeding frequency in particular, this package says so and explains which way to weight it, rather than picking a number and pretending it is settled.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A reptile-experienced veterinarian. Get a new corn snake checked within the first few weeks, and plan an annual wellness exam with a fecal test after that. Find the vet before you need one, and write the number on page 15.

SECTION 01

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Pantherophis guttatus</i> , a North American rat snake
Adult size	3.5 to 5 ft (107 to 152 cm), slender-bodied
Captive lifespan	10 to 15 years typical, with documented individuals to 22
Native range	Eastern and central United States; pine forest, woodland, and farmland
Diet type	Carnivore; whole frozen-thawed rodents, no supplementation needed
Enclosure minimum (adult)	40 gal breeder (36×18×18 in); 4×2×2 ft preferred
Escape risk	High. Notorious escape artists, so the lid has to latch
Handling difficulty	Beginner; juveniles are fast and defensive, adults are famously docile
Conservation status	Least Concern (IUCN)

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$250 to \$600 for a solid basic setup, reaching about \$1,150 for a PVC enclosure with UVB and premium fixtures. A normal-morph snake is \$25 to \$70.

Annual ongoing

\$200 to \$500 once the setup is finished, covering frozen rodents, substrate, the electricity to run heat continuously, and a wellness exam.

LOW RUNNING COST, LONG COMMITMENT

An adult eats every 14 to 21 days, which keeps the food budget among the lowest of any pet its size. Spread the setup across a 15 to 20 year lifespan and the per-year cost is genuinely small, but it is still a two-decade animal.

Fun facts worth knowing

- The name comes from the belly scales, whose checkered pattern resembles Indian corn kernels, not from the cornfields they hunt rodents in, though both stories get told.
- A corn snake vibrating its tail against dry substrate sounds remarkably like a rattlesnake. It is a defensive bluff that works well on predators, and the snake has no rattle at all.
- They are excellent climbers and semi-arboreal, which is why a stable branch gets used far more than most keepers expect from a species labeled terrestrial.
- They are the best-studied snake in the hobby. Three separate 2021 papers on this species alone sit behind page 9.

Enclosure & the thermostat rule

Corn snakes are terrestrial, so floor space matters more than height, though they will use a stable branch when one is offered. The adult minimum is a 40-gallon breeder at 36×18×18 inches, with 4×2×2 ft (48×24×24 in) preferred for a fully grown adult. Front-opening PVC is generally better than glass: it holds humidity more effectively and tends to be more escape-proof, which matters here more than with most species. House corn snakes singly.



40 gal breeder (36 × 18 × 18 in) minimum, 4 × 2 × 2 ft preferred. Longer than the snake.
Secure, locking, front-opening. A gap at the corner of a screen top is all it takes.

THE ONE RULE WITH ZERO EXCEPTIONS

Every heat source runs through a thermostat. An unregulated heat mat can climb to around 120°F, which is hot enough to cause a serious burn on an animal that will lie directly on it. Place the probe where your snake actually spends time, inside the warm hide or on the substrate surface, not taped to the mat itself, which gives a misleading reading. Never use a hot rock.

Temperature, humidity & lighting

ZONE	TARGET
Warm side surface	85 to 88°F (some sources accept 80 to 85°F)
Cool side	72 to 78°F
Overall ambient	75 to 82°F
Nighttime	65 to 75°F
Humidity, higher-baseline sources	65 to 75%
Humidity, conventional sources	40 to 60%, raised to 60 to 70% during a shed

Measure humidity with a digital hygrometer at substrate level, not up near the lid, where readings run drier than what the snake actually experiences. The one number worth holding firmly: a corn snake needs roughly 82°F or more on the warm side to digest a meal safely, so a warm side running cool is a feeding problem before it is anything else.

The humidity disagreement, and how to sidestep it

This is a genuine split. Some specialist husbandry guides recommend a higher baseline of 65 to 75%, arguing that wild corn snake habitat runs more humid than conventional reptile-keeping wisdom assumes. Many other sources and vets cite 40 to 60% as sufficient, raised to 60 to 70% specifically during shedding. In practice either range works, and plenty of corn snakes have thrived for decades under the drier guidance.

What settles it in practice is consistency plus a dedicated humid hide packed with damp sphagnum moss, so the snake can access higher humidity during a shed regardless of what the rest of the enclosure reads. That single furnishing removes most of the reason to argue about the baseline at all.

UVB, optional but increasingly recommended

Not required, and corn snakes have been kept successfully without it for decades, but it is increasingly viewed as beneficial for long-term health. If you add it, use a low-output T5 spanning about half the enclosure on the warm side, targeting a UVI around 2.0 to 3.0.

Photoperiod, not optional

A 12 hour light, 12 hour dark cycle either way, using a basic LED on a timer if you skip UVB. Avoid bright or colored bulbs at night; use a ceramic heat emitter if you genuinely need supplemental night heat.

Signs your setup needs adjusting

YOU NOTICE	LIKELY MEANS
Shed coming off in pieces, or retained eye caps	Humidity too low through the shed cycle
A meal brought back up a day or two later	Warm side too cool to digest, or handled too soon
Substrate staying damp, condensation on the walls	Too wet or too little ventilation, scale rot risk
Sitting on the cool side and refusing to move	Warm side too hot; check the probe placement

Substrate, furnishings & handling

Substrate

Aspen shavings are the classic choice: they dry quickly and suit a lower-humidity setup well. Coconut fiber, cypress mulch, or a soil-based mix work better if you run toward the higher end of the humidity range. Whatever you choose, keep it 3 to 4 inches deep so the snake can burrow, which it will. Spot-clean daily and do a full substrate change every 3 to 4 months.

NEVER

Pine or cedar, both of which contain oils toxic to reptiles. Also skip gravel and loose bark chips, which carry an impaction risk, and hot rocks, which are a well-documented burn hazard and add nothing a properly regulated heat source does not already do better.

Furnishings checklist

- ☐ Two hides minimum, one warm side and one cool side
- ☐ Humid hide with damp sphagnum moss, kept year round
- ☐ Sturdy water bowl large enough to soak in, changed twice a week
- ☐ Cork tubes and flats for floor-level cover
- ☐ A firmly braced branch, since they are semi-arboreal
- ☐ Leaf litter or plants to interrupt open sightlines

Handling

Give a new corn snake time to acclimate and eat successfully three or four times, roughly one to two weeks at minimum, before handling. Keep early sessions to 5 or 10 minutes, no more than a couple of times a week, and build up gradually. For hatchlings, start as short as 1 to 2 minutes. Juveniles can be fast, wiggly, and genuinely defensive before they settle into the calm temperament adults are known for, so patience early pays off later.

Make sure the snake is actually awake first, since a gentle tap with a paper-towel roll or a hook stops it mistaking your hand for food. Approach from the side rather than straight down from above, support as much of the body as you can with both hands, and let the snake move through them rather than trying to hold it still. Never grab or restrain the head or tail.

THE TWO TIMING RULES

Wait 48 to 72 hours after a meal before handling, since handling too soon is one of the most common causes of regurgitation. And skip handling during a shed: cloudy or blue eyes mean the snake is functionally blind and more likely to bite out of startlement rather than temperament.

Signs to end the session

Rapid tongue-flicking, tight coiling, musking, striking, tail rattling or vibrating, and fast erratic movement. Stay calm if you see them: it is usually better to let a brief tantrum settle before returning the snake to its enclosure than to put it back mid-thrash, which reinforces the behavior. Bites are rare and minor, typically a startled reaction rather than aggression, and treated with soap and water. Corn snakes carry *Salmonella* like virtually all reptiles, so wash hands before and after every session and supervise handling for children.

Diet & feeding by age and weight

The schedule below is keyed to weight as well as age, which is the more useful pairing. Let body condition and monthly weigh-ins guide you more than the calendar does.

STAGE	WEIGHT	FREQUENCY
Hatchling (0 to 3 months)	Under about 30 g	Every 5 to 7 days, starting on pinky mice
Young juvenile (3 to 9 months)	30 to 100 g	Every 7 days
Juvenile (9 to 18 months)	100 to 300 g	Every 7 to 10 days
Sub-adult (18 to 36 months)	300 to 600 g	Every 10 to 14 days
Adult (3+ years)	600 g+	Every 14 to 21 days

A vet-content source gives a notably more frequent version across the board, every other day for babies and weekly for juveniles. That is a real disagreement, roughly a 2 to 3× difference for hatchlings. The specialist schedule above is more consistent across independent sources and is worth weighting more heavily, but it is not silently settled.

Prey size

Roughly 1 to 1.5 times the width of the snake at its widest point, or about 10 to 15% of body weight per meal. Two smaller items can substitute for one larger one if you are between sizes. Don't feed on too tight a schedule once the snake is adult: one source warns it can produce obesity within 12 to 18 months.

Thawing

Thaw in the refrigerator overnight, then warm in warm, not boiling, water to roughly 98 to 102°F to mimic living prey. Never microwave, and never re-freeze prey that has been thawed and refused.

NEVER FEED

Live prey, which can bite, scratch, or claw a snake that isn't ready to strike, and cause a serious infection. Wild-caught prey of any kind. Meat scraps or cooked food. Prey that has been thawed, refused, and re-frozen. And insects, which are not a natural food for this species and which corn snakes reportedly have an aversion to anyway.

SUPPLEMENTATION IS MOSTLY UNNECESSARY HERE

A whole-prey diet, bones and organs included, is nutritionally complete, unlike an insect-based reptile diet. Where dusting is used at all it is for hatchlings on pinky mice, a light calcium and multivitamin dusting every 3 to 4 feedings, tapering off on larger prey. Over-supplementing calcium can itself cause mineral imbalance or kidney stress.

Common mistakes & enrichment

Mistakes that cause the most harm

- Running any heat source without a thermostat, which is the one rule in this package with no nuance attached.
- Taping the thermostat probe to the mat rather than placing it where the snake lies, which reads the equipment instead of the animal.
- Using "snakes feel secure in small spaces" to justify a small enclosure, when a preference test disagrees.
- Adding space without adding cover, which produces an unused enclosure and then gets read as evidence the snake wanted less room.
- A lid that does not latch. Corn snakes are notorious escape artists and a corner gap is all it takes.
- Handling within 48 hours of a meal, then treating the regurgitation as bad luck.
- Feeding an adult on a juvenile's schedule, which produces obesity within 12 to 18 months.
- Chasing a humidity number with a spray bottle instead of providing a humid hide.

THE ENCLOSURE SIZE QUESTION HAS A PREFERENCE TEST BEHIND IT

Hoehfurtner and colleagues housed corn snakes in enclosures either two thirds of their body length or longer than their body length. When they had room to stretch out completely, they did, and they showed a clear preference for the larger enclosure. The authors' recommendation is that captive snakes be kept in enclosures that allow them to stretch. Two further 2021 papers from the same group looked at added complexity and at scent discrimination, where enrichment changed how well snakes told familiar from unfamiliar human odor.

Enrichment, by priority

1. An enclosure longer than the snake

For most animals size and enrichment are separate line items. For corn snakes the research collapses them, because stretching, exploring, and moving between microclimates all require length first. A 4×2×2 ft comfortably exceeds body length for an adult.

3. A stable climbing structure

They are semi-arboreal and will use height when it is stable. A firmly braced branch or a stack of cork gives a second usable level. Height does not substitute for length, but on top of adequate floor space it gets used.

2. Cover across the whole floor

More space only helps if the snake will cross it. A corn snake in a large bare enclosure uses two hides and nothing else. Cork tubes and flats, leaf litter, and plants dense enough to interrupt sightlines let it move end to end without ever being fully exposed.

4. Scent, then novelty last

A shed from another enclosure, a scent-marked object, or prey dragged across the substrate invites investigation, and the odor study suggests the channel is worth using. Rearrangement comes last: rebuilding weekly removes the familiarity the snake navigates by.

Health red flags

What to watch for, and what to actually tell the vet.

CONTACT A REPTILE VET PROMPTLY IF YOU SEE

Open-mouth breathing, wheezing, or an audible clicking sound · mucus or discharge around the nose or mouth · belly scales that are discolored, soft, mushy, or blistered · visible mites · swollen or reddened gums, or discharge in the mouth · repeated regurgitation · star-gazing or corkscrewing movements · weight loss with diarrhea despite normal eating

Almost everything here is husbandry, not luck

Corn snakes are one of the hardier pet snakes, and nearly every health problem they develop traces back to temperature, humidity, or substrate rather than to bad luck. Get those three right and most of Section 03 stays theoretical. That also means a vet will ask about your setup first, so having the numbers ready shortens the visit and often changes the diagnosis.

What to tell the vet

- ☐ Warm side and cool side temperatures, and whether heat runs on a thermostat

☐ Current humidity, and where in the enclosure you measured it

☐ Date of the last meal and whether it stayed down
- ☐ Date and quality of the last shed, including eye caps

☐ Weight trend from your monthly weigh-ins

☐ Substrate type and when it was last fully changed

Normal vs. concerning

NORMAL	CONCERNING
Refusing food for 5 to 7 days before a shed, with cloudy eyes	Refusal alongside weight loss, lethargy, or wheezing
Burrowing under the substrate and staying out of sight for days	Sitting on the cool side, unmoving, refusing to use the warm end
Tail vibrating against substrate when startled	Persistent open-mouth breathing or clicking
A soak in the water bowl, most often around a shed	Soaking constantly, or rubbing persistently against surfaces
Reduced appetite in a male through breeding season	A hatchling refusing food for over about a week

Respiratory infection & scale rot

Respiratory infection

Cause: usually bacterial, and almost always secondary to an enclosure that is too cold or too damp. It is the most common issue in pet corn snakes. **Signs:** open-mouth breathing, wheezing or an audible clicking sound, mucus or discharge around the nose or mouth, and lethargy. **Diagnosis:** physical exam and listening to the lungs, with the vet asking directly about your temperature setup. **Response:** a reptile vet and prescription antibiotics, not a wait-and-see approach, and correcting the temperature and humidity in parallel or it recurs. **Recovery:** good when caught early; left untreated it can become serious quickly.

LEARN THIS ONE BY SOUND

A clicking or wheezing corn snake is the single clearest audible signal in this package. If you hear it, raise the warm side to target, check humidity at substrate level, and call a reptile vet. Do not wait a week to see whether it settles.

Scale rot (necrotic dermatitis)

Cause: a bacterial infection of the belly scales, usually from damp or dirty substrate, or a water bowl that has been overflowing or sitting unchanged too long. **Signs:** belly scales discolored brown, yellow, or black, skin that looks soft, mushy, or blistered, and a foul smell. **Response:** fix the underlying husbandry immediately, move the snake to clean dry substrate, and see a vet, especially if it is spreading. **Recovery:** affected scales generally resolve over the next one to two shed cycles once the environment is corrected.

THE COMMON THREAD

These are the same problem approached from two directions. Respiratory infection follows cold and damp; scale rot follows substrate that never dries out. Both are prevented by a warm side that actually holds its target, real ventilation, and a water bowl that gets changed rather than topped up. The humid hide gives the snake the moisture it needs without turning the whole enclosure into the condition that causes both.

Mites, mouth rot & retained shed

Mites

Cause: almost always introduced, on a new snake, on used decor, or from a shop or expo. **Signs:** tiny black or red specks moving on the scales or floating in the water bowl, often with the snake soaking excessively or rubbing against surfaces.

Why they matter: irritation, and in significant infestations anemia and real stress on the animal. **Response:** treating the snake alone is not enough. The whole enclosure has to be treated at the same time or the infestation simply comes back, which usually means stripping substrate completely and repeating on the schedule your vet sets.

Mouth rot (infectious stomatitis)

Cause: an infection of the mouth tissue, typically secondary to stress, injury, or ongoing poor husbandry rather than arriving alone. **Signs:** swollen or reddened gums and visible discharge, sometimes with reluctance to feed. **Response:** veterinary treatment. This does not resolve with home care, and because it usually rides on top of another problem, the visit should come with an honest account of your setup.

Retained shed (dysecdysis)

Cause: almost always a humidity problem. **Signs:** patches of skin that did not come off cleanly, and retained eye caps.

Prevention: a humid hide with damp sphagnum moss available during shed cycles prevents most of it, along with a rough surface such as cork for the snake to start the shed against. **Never** peel skin off by force.

CHECK THE EYE CAPS EVERY TIME

Retained eye caps are one of the easiest shed problems to miss, because a corn snake's vision and behavior often look completely normal with one still in place. That is exactly why every shed is worth a quick visual check rather than just confirming the old skin came off in one piece. A retained cap needs a vet, not a home attempt.

QUARANTINE IS THE ACTUAL FIX FOR MITES

Keep a new snake fully separate, on paper towel in a simple setup, with separate tools and hand-washing between enclosures, for long enough to be confident it is clean before it goes anywhere near an established animal.

Regurgitation, refusal & brumation

Regurgitation

Bringing a meal back up hours to days after eating, usually from handling too soon after a meal or from a warm side too cool to digest properly. It is hard on the digestive system and repeated episodes cause real damage. After one, leave the snake alone for 10 to 14 days, then offer a smaller than usual prey item. Repeated regurgitation is a vet visit rather than a feeding adjustment. Check the warm side reading first: 82°F or more is what safe digestion needs.

Why corn snakes stop eating

- **Shedding.** Appetite typically drops 5 to 7 days before a shed, recognizable by eyes clouding or turning milky blue, and sometimes for a short window after.
- **Brumation.** A seasonal instinct or a deliberate breeder practice, covered below.
- **Breeding season, mainly males.** Males may stop eating for weeks to months after brumation while searching for a mate, showing restlessness and tongue-flicking instead. Normal as long as the snake stays active and holds condition.
- **Environmental stress.** Recent rehoming, cage changes, excessive handling, or too few hides. Waiting about 48 hours after any disturbance before offering food again is common advice.
- **A warm side that isn't warm enough.** A fixable husbandry problem, not a benign phase.
- **Prey presentation.** Improperly thawed or cold prey, or a snake balking at a switch from live to frozen-thawed. Scenting the prey is a commonly cited fix.
- **Illness or parasites.** Only likely when refusal comes with other symptoms.

THE SOURCES DISAGREE ON WHEN TO WORRY, AND BOTH HAVE A POINT

A healthy adult can physically survive roughly 2 to 3 months without food, and reptile-specialist sources describe refusal as unremarkable until it passes about 1 to 2 months outside a planned brumation. A more conservative vet-content source recommends a call after just a couple of missed feedings. Those are keeper field experience and standard vet caution talking past each other. Monthly weigh-ins are a better guide than counting days: give benefit of the doubt to a snake that is active and holding weight, not to one that is lethargic or visibly thinning. A hatchling going over about a week is already worth taking seriously.

Brumation

A seasonal slowdown, done deliberately by gradually dropping enclosure temperatures over 1 to 2 weeks, followed by 2 to 4 months without food. A mandatory 10 to 14 day fast at normal temperature has to come first: undigested food in a cooling gut can rot and cause a fatal infection. This is not something to do casually or by accident, and if your snake goes quiet in winter without you having planned it, confirm with a vet that you are looking at brumation rather than illness.

Setup checklist & climate targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ 40 gal breeder minimum, 4×2×2 ft preferred
- ☐ Heat source sized to the enclosure
- ☐ Digital thermometer and hygrometer, read at substrate level
- ☐ Two hides, warm side and cool side
- ☐ Water bowl large enough to soak in
- ☐ Timer for a 12 hour light, 12 hour dark cycle
- ☐ Secure, locking, front-opening. PVC over glass
- ☐ Thermostat, one per heat source, no exceptions
- ☐ Aspen, coconut fiber, or cypress mulch, 3 to 4 in deep
- ☐ Humid hide with sphagnum moss
- ☐ Cork, a braced branch, and leaf litter for cover
- ☐ Frozen-thawed rodent supply and feeding tongs

Climate targets

TARGET	RANGE
Warm side surface	85 to 88°F (80 to 85°F accepted by some sources)
Minimum for safe digestion	About 82°F on the warm side
Cool side	72 to 78°F
Overall ambient	75 to 82°F
Nighttime	65 to 75°F
Humidity	40 to 60% or 65 to 75% by source; 60 to 70% through a shed
UVI, if you add UVB	2.0 to 3.0
Photoperiod	12 hours light / 12 hours dark

Before your snake comes home

- ☐ Enclosure running for 24 to 48 hours with stable readings
- ☐ Lid latch tested. Assume the snake will try it
- ☐ Frozen prey in the freezer, at the size the seller was using
- ☐ Thermostat probe placed where the snake will lie, not on the mat
- ☐ Humid hide damp and in place from day one
- ☐ Reptile-experienced vet identified, with hours noted

Emergency & quick targets

CALL A REPTILE VET IF YOU SEE

Open-mouth breathing, wheezing, or clicking · mucus at the nose or mouth · belly scales discolored, soft, or blistered · visible mites · swollen gums or mouth discharge · repeated regurgitation · star-gazing or corkscrewing · weight loss with diarrhea · a burn over the heat source

READING	TARGET
Warm side surface	85 to 88°F
Minimum to digest a meal	About 82°F
Cool side	72 to 78°F
Nighttime low	65 to 75°F
Humidity, through a shed	60 to 70%
Feeding, adult	Every 14 to 21 days
Wait after feeding before handling	48 to 72 hours
Rest after a regurgitation	10 to 14 days, then smaller prey

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

Warm and cool side temperatures, whether heat runs on a thermostat, current humidity and where you measured it, the date of the last meal and whether it stayed down, the date and quality of the last shed, and the weight trend from your log.

MY VET

Practice: _____ Phone: _____

Out of hours: _____ Nearest exotic ER: _____

Budget & shopping list

ITEM	TYPICAL COST
The snake, normal morph	\$25 to \$70
Enclosure (40 gal breeder glass, or 4×2×2 ft PVC)	\$80 to \$400
Heat source (under-tank heat mat or overhead halogen)	\$15 to \$50
Thermostat	\$30 to \$100
Substrate	\$10 to \$30
Hides, at least two, plus a humid hide	\$10 to \$40
Water bowl and decor	\$30 to \$70
Digital thermometer and hygrometer	\$10 to \$40
Optional UVB setup	\$50 to \$150
Initial vet exam	\$50 to \$160
Total initial setup	\$250 to \$600 , up to about \$1,150 for a full PVC and UVB build
Frozen mice or rats (annual)	\$120 to \$240
Substrate (annual)	\$30 to \$80
Electricity, heat running continuously (annual)	\$60 to \$180
Annual vet wellness exam	\$50 to \$150
Annual ongoing	\$200 to \$500

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

The thermostat and the enclosure. The thermostat is the difference between a heat source and a burn, at a cost of \$30 to \$100. The enclosure is the item with a preference test behind it, and it is also the escape-proofing. Save on decor and the optional UVB before you save on either.

THE LONG VIEW

Spread \$250 to \$600 of setup across a 15 to 20 year lifespan, on a food budget driven by a meal every two to three weeks, and the corn snake is one of the cheapest long-lived pets there is to run. The expensive year is the first one.

First 30 days checklist

Week 1

- ☐ Confirm warm side, cool side, and humidity with real instruments, not by feel
- ☐ Hands off entirely: spot-cleaning and fresh water only
- ☐ Offer the first meal at the end of the week, at the size and prey type the seller was using
- ☐ Note the seller's feeding schedule, last meal date, and last shed date in your log

Week 2 to 3

- ☐ Handle only after the snake has eaten successfully three or four times
- ☐ Keep sessions to 5 to 10 minutes, twice a week at most, never within 48 to 72 hours of a meal
- ☐ Book a wellness exam with a reptile-experienced vet, ideally with a fecal test
- ☐ Start the Owner Log on page 20, including weight

Week 4

- ☐ Take the first monthly weight and record it as your baseline
- ☐ Confirm the humid hide is still genuinely damp and refresh the moss
- ☐ Introduce first enrichment items from page 21, one at a time
- ☐ Re-test the lid latch and check for any gap a growing snake could work at

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Watch the first shed closely and log its quality, including eye caps
- ☐ Settle into the weight-based feeding interval from page 8
- ☐ Review the log for slow drift in weight, humidity, or temperature rather than single readings
- ☐ Start rotating enrichment on the monthly schedule from page 21

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Open-mouth breathing, wheezing, clicking	Respiratory infection	Reptile vet promptly (page 11)
Belly scales discolored, soft, or blistered	Scale rot	Dry, clean setup now; vet if spreading (page 11)
Black or red specks on scales or in the water	Mites	Vet + full enclosure treatment (page 12)
Swollen gums, mouth discharge	Mouth rot	Vet, does not self-resolve (page 12)
Shed in patches, or retained eye caps	Humidity too low	Humid hide, raise to 60 to 70% (page 12)
Meal brought back up a day or two later	Regurgitation	Rest 10 to 14 days; check warm side (page 13)
Refusing food with cloudy blue eyes	Coming into shed	Normal. Wait it out (page 13)
Refusing food, active, holding weight	Season, stress, or presentation	Work through the list on page 13
Refusing food with weight loss or lethargy	Several possible causes	Vet visit, bring the Owner Log (page 20)
Weight loss and diarrhea despite eating	Internal parasites	Vet with a fecal sample (page 10)
Star-gazing or corkscrewing movement	Neurological	Immediate vet visit (page 10)
Burn mark over the heat source	Unregulated heat	Vet; fit a thermostat before anything else (page 5)

Daily & weekly routine

Daily

- ☐ Check warm side, cool side, and humidity readings
- ☐ Spot-clean any waste
- ☐ Confirm the lid is properly latched
- ☐ Quick visual check: eyes, mouth, belly scales, breathing

Weekly

- ☐ Change the water bowl at least twice, scrubbing rather than topping up
- ☐ Feed per the weight-based interval on page 8, and log it
- ☐ Check the humid hide is still damp and refresh the moss
- ☐ Rotate or refresh one enrichment item

Monthly

- ☐ Weigh the snake. Monthly weight is the guide the feeding schedule hangs on
- ☐ Verify the thermostat holds its set point and the probe has not shifted
- ☐ Review the Owner Log for slow trends rather than single readings
- ☐ Check hides still fit snugly and the branch is still firmly braced

Quarterly and seasonal

- ☐ Full substrate change every 3 to 4 months
- ☐ Reassess room temperature swings between summer and winter
- ☐ Expect reduced appetite in cooler months, and in males through breeding season
- ☐ Check that dry indoor heating has not pulled humidity below range

Owner log

Photocopy this page, or track digitally. Consistency matters more than the format.

DATE	WEIGHT	WARM °F	COOL °F	HUMIDITY	NOTES

WHY BOTHER LOGGING

The feeding schedule on page 8 is keyed to weight, not just age, so a monthly weigh-in is what makes it usable. It is also the number that decides whether a fast is routine or a symptom, and it is the first thing a reptile vet will ask you for.

Feeding & shed log

DATE	PREY / EVENT	OUTCOME

Vet visit log

DATE	REASON	FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment checklist

Setup

- ☐ An enclosure longer than the snake, so it can stretch out fully
- ☐ Cover distributed across the entire floor, not only at the two hides
- ☐ A firmly braced branch or stacked cork for a second level
- ☐ Leaf litter or plants dense enough to interrupt sightlines
- ☐ Substrate deep enough to burrow into, 3 to 4 in

Monthly review

- ☐ Offer a scent novelty: a shed from another enclosure, or prey dragged across the substrate before offering
- ☐ Add or reposition one piece of cover, without blocking the warm end
- ☐ Check whether the snake is using more of the floor than last month, not less
- ☐ Confirm the branch is still stable enough to take the snake's weight

WHAT NOT TO DO

Don't use "snakes feel secure in small spaces" to justify a small enclosure, because a preference test disagrees. Don't add space without adding cover, since that produces an unused enclosure that then gets read as evidence the snake wanted less room. Don't treat handling as enrichment. And don't rearrange constantly, because a rebuilt enclosure every week removes the familiarity the snake is navigating by.

Enrichment log

DATE	CHANGE MADE	HOW IT WENT

Glossary

Thermostat	The device that regulates a heat source to a set temperature. Not the same as a dimmer or a timer, and not optional.
Dysecdysis	Incomplete or "stuck" shedding, in this species almost always a humidity problem.
Eye cap	The clear scale covering the eye, shed with the rest of the skin. A retained cap is easy to miss and needs a vet.
Humid hide	A closed hide packed with damp sphagnum moss, giving the snake a high-humidity pocket it can choose to use.
F/T	Frozen-thawed prey, the standard and safer alternative to live feeding.
Regurgitation	Bringing a meal back up after swallowing, most often from handling too soon or a warm side too cool to digest.
Brumation	A reptile's seasonal winter slowdown. Done deliberately it requires a 10 to 14 day fast at normal temperature first.
Scale rot	Necrotic dermatitis of the belly scales, driven by damp or dirty substrate.
Stomatitis	Mouth rot: infection of the mouth tissue, usually secondary to stress or poor husbandry.
Star-gazing	Holding the head tilted up and back. A rare but serious neurological sign needing an immediate vet visit.
Musking	A foul-smelling defensive release. A clear signal to end a handling session.
Morph	A selectively bred color or pattern variant. Corn snakes have a very large number of them, and a normal is not a lesser snake.

Compiled from veterinary and herpetological sources, including the three 2021 corn snake enclosure and enrichment papers cited on page 9, and cross-checked against current Beastly Facts guides at time of publication. Where sources genuinely disagree, particularly on humidity baseline and hatchling feeding frequency, this package says so rather than choosing one silently. This is a husbandry reference, not a substitute for a reptile-experienced veterinarian, and is not a live website mirror. No external links or website CTAs appear in this document.

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